LAW 4 WARRIORS | JUSTICE FOR OUR HEROES

AI Claims Operations System Plan

A single private system to run intake, case analysis, evidence building, form preparation, filing support, and client communication for VA disability claims and appeals - so the firm's lawyers spend their time on law, not paperwork.

Prepared for: The Partners, Law 4 Warriors

Purpose: A practical plan for discussion and decision - what to build, in what order, what it saves, and the guardrails that keep it ethical and compliant.

Status: Planning document. All time and savings figures are planning estimates, not guarantees. This plan is not legal advice.

October 2026 • Confidential - for internal partner review

The short version: the practice does not have a law problem. It has a paperwork problem - hundreds of pages per veteran, the same facts typed again and again, and one-year deadlines that cannot be missed. This system attacks that problem directly, with a human attorney or accredited agent approving everything that leaves the building.

1 EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The bottleneck is paperwork, not law

Law 4 Warriors wins cases on judgment: which conditions to claim, how to connect them to service, and which appeal lane to choose. The hours, however, go somewhere else - interviewing, typing, reading record files page by page, re-entering the same facts into VA forms, and tracking deadlines by hand. This plan replaces that manual chain with one connected system.

What the system is

One private web application, used only by the firm, that carries a case from the first inquiry to a filed appeal and beyond. It has five connected parts - called engines in this plan - covering smart intake, rating-decision analysis, evidence building, forms and filings, and client communication. They all work from a single verified case file, so information is entered once, checked once, and reused everywhere it is needed.

Why it matters now

VA disability work is unusually well suited to this kind of help. The forms are standard. The rating rules are published. The records, while long, follow recognizable patterns. The deadlines are fixed and unforgiving. None of that requires a lawyer's judgment to move from one step to the next - it requires accuracy, completeness, and relentless follow-through, which is exactly where software is strongest and tired humans are most at risk.

2-3x

Estimated caseload the same team can carry once routine admin is automated. Planning estimate - see Time & Money.

40-60%

Estimated share of administrative hours removed per case. Planning estimate based on the task table in Section 6.

Zero

Target for missed filing deadlines, protected by automated alarms at 90, 60, 30, and 7 days.

> **The headline benefit, in one sentence:** the same staff handles two to three times the caseload, every case gets a complete and consistent file, and no veteran loses back pay because a one-year window slipped past unnoticed.

How to read this plan: the opening sections describe the problem and the system. Then come the time math (estimates throughout), compliance, how the website and secure system connect, build order and risks, operating costs, and finally the recommended next step - a short scoping session and a small working prototype before any full commitment.

Where the hours go today

Ask anyone who runs a VA practice where the week went and the answer is rarely "arguing the law." It is the five drains below. Each one is necessary work. None of it needs to be done the slow way.

1. Intake interviews and data entry

A proper intake captures service history, deployments, current conditions, current ratings, prior claims and denials, and contact and dependent details. Done by phone and keyboard, it takes 45 to 90 minutes of staff time, produces inconsistent notes, and often has to be redone when a document later contradicts what was written down.

2. Reading the record - hundreds of pages at a time

Service treatment records, VA medical records, private treatment notes, and prior decision letters can run to hundreds of pages per veteran. Someone has to read them, find the in-service event, find the current diagnosis, and connect the two. That search is slow, it is easy to miss a key page, and the next person on the case usually has to search all over again.

3. Re-typing the same facts into VA forms

The veteran's name, file number, service dates, conditions, and history get typed into form after form - the claim, the supplemental claim, the request for higher-level review, the Board appeal. Every re-typing is a fresh chance for a typo in exactly the fields where a typo causes delay.

4. Tracking one-year deadlines by hand

In the modern VA appeals system, a claimant generally has one year from a decision to file a Supplemental Claim, a request for Higher-Level Review, or a Notice of Disagreement to the Board while preserving the earliest possible effective date. Miss that window and the veteran can still pursue the benefit - but months or years of back pay tied to the earlier date can be lost. Today those dates often live in spreadsheets, sticky notes, and individual memory.

5. Chasing clients and answering "any news?"

Staff time leaks away in small pieces: calls and texts asking for a DD214, a signed form, or a doctor's address - and inbound calls from veterans who simply want to know where their case stands. Every unanswered status question erodes trust in a client base that has already waited a long time for the VA.

> **The cost is not just hours.** It is inconsistency (two staff members build two different files), fragility (one person's absence stalls their cases), and risk (one missed date harms a veteran in a way no later effort can fully repair).

3 THE SYSTEM

Five engines, one verified case file

Think of the system as a well-run back office. Each engine does one job, hands its work to the next, and writes everything into the same case file. Nothing is typed twice, and nothing leaves the firm without a human approving it.

ENGINE A

Smart Intake

Interviews the veteran, collects documents, and extracts the facts automatically.

ENGINE B

Rating-Decision Analyzer

Reads VA decision letters and shows the attorney where the opportunity is.

ENGINE C

Evidence Builder

Turns the record into chronologies, draft statements, and doctor-ready packets.

ENGINE D

Forms & Filings

Fills the VA forms from the verified file and guards every deadline.

ENGINE E

Client Autopilot

Keeps the veteran informed automatically and shows staff every case, stage, and next step on one dashboard.

Three rules the whole system follows

- **Enter once, verify once, reuse everywhere.** A fact checked at intake flows into the analysis, the evidence packet, and every form.
- **The system drafts; people decide.** Software organizes, calculates, and prepares. Accredited attorneys and agents make the legal calls and approve every filing and every statement sent in a veteran's name.
- **Every action is logged.** Who viewed, changed, approved, or filed anything - and when - is recorded in a full audit trail.

Plain-language note: "OCR and extraction" in the pages that follow simply means the software reads scanned documents - including faxes and older records - and pulls out names, dates, diagnoses, and decisions into usable fields, instead of a person typing them.

Intake in minutes. Decisions read for opportunity.

ENGINE A

Smart Intake

WHAT IT DOES

Conducts a guided, conversational interview - on the website, by phone, or by text - asking the questions a good paralegal would ask, in order, and following up when an answer opens a new line (for example, a knee injury that may have led to a back condition).

WHAT GOES IN

The veteran's answers, plus secure uploads: DD Form 214, service treatment records, VA and private medical records, and prior decision letters.

WHAT COMES OUT / HUMAN ROLE

A structured, searchable case file with key facts extracted - service dates, conditions claimed and already rated, prior denials. Staff review it for accuracy in an estimated 10 minutes instead of a 45- to 90-minute manual intake, and handle the personal welcome themselves.

ENGINE B

Rating-Decision Analyzer

WHAT IT DOES

Lists each condition decided, the rating assigned, and the reason for any denial or low rating. It then runs the VA combined-ratings calculation under 38 CFR Section 4.25 - where percentages combine rather than simply add - and checks it against what VA awarded.

WHAT IT FLAGS FOR THE ATTORNEY

- Conditions that appear underrated against the rating criteria
- Secondary conditions suggested by the record but never claimed (for example, sleep apnea in connection with PTSD)
- Conditions that may qualify as presumptive under the PACT Act based on service and exposure history
- Possible eligibility for Total Disability based on Individual Unemployability (TDIU)
- Effective-date errors - an award dated later than the record supports

WHAT COMES OUT / HUMAN ROLE

A short case-opportunity report for the attorney. The attorney decides what is legally sound and what to pursue; the system makes no merits decision on its own.

Evidence organized. Forms filled. Deadlines guarded.

ENGINE C

Evidence Builder

WHAT IT DOES

Converts a bulky record file into a clear, per-condition chronology: the in-service event or treatment, the post-service complaints, and the current diagnosis, laid out in date order with a link back to the exact source page for every entry.

WHAT COMES OUT

- A timeline for each claimed condition, matched against the diagnosis it is meant to support
- Draft buddy and lay statements, prepared from a structured interview with the veteran or witness - in their facts, for their review and signature
- Nexus-letter packets for physicians: a concise summary and the relevant records, organized so a doctor can review, edit, and sign efficiently

WHAT THE HUMAN STILL DOES

Everything in this engine is a draft. Staff and the attorney verify each fact against its source page, and no statement, letter, or assertion is used until the person signing it has approved it as true.

ENGINE D

Forms & Filings

WHAT IT DOES

Fills VA forms directly from the verified case file and prepares them for filing through the submission channels available to accredited representatives.

FORMS COVERED

VA Form 21-526EZ (disability compensation claim), VA Form 20-0995 (Supplemental Claim), VA Form 20-0996 (Request for Higher-Level Review), VA Form 10182 (Decision Review Request: Board Appeal - Notice of Disagreement), and VA Form 21-22a (appointment of an accredited attorney or agent as representative).

THE DEADLINE ENGINE

Every decision date starts a clock. The system tracks the one-year windows that protect a veteran's effective date and escalates alarms at 90, 60, 30, and 7 days - to the assigned staff member, then to a supervisor - until the filing is confirmed. A case cannot quietly age past its window.

WHAT THE HUMAN STILL DOES

An accredited attorney or agent reviews and approves every form before it is filed. Approval is a deliberate step in the system, not a default.

Clients who always know where they stand

ENGINE E

Client Autopilot

WHAT IT DOES

Sends automatic status updates by text and email at every meaningful stage - documents received, claim filed, decision received, appeal filed - plus polite, scheduled reminders when a document or signature is still needed, and simple appointment scheduling for calls and exams preparation.

WHAT STAFF SEE

One dashboard: every case, its current stage, its next action, who owns it, and its next deadline - sorted so the most urgent work is always at the top. A manager can see the whole practice's workload in a single glance.

WHAT THE HUMAN STILL DOES

People handle people. Difficult news, strategy conversations, and any veteran who is distressed or confused get a human call - the automation exists to free up time for exactly those conversations.

The life of a case, step by step

1. **First click.** The veteran completes the guided intake on the website (or by phone/text with staff support) and uploads documents securely.
2. **Review and acceptance.** Staff verify the extracted file in about 10 minutes (estimate). The attorney reviews the case and the representation paperwork (Form 21-22a) is prepared.
3. **Analysis.** Any prior decision is analyzed for ratings, secondaries, presumptives, TDIU, and effective dates. The attorney sets the claim strategy.
4. **Evidence.** Chronologies are built, gaps are identified, and draft statements and nexus packets are prepared and approved.
5. **Filing.** Forms are generated from the verified file, approved by the accredited representative, and filed. The deadline clock for the next stage starts automatically.
6. **Monitoring and appeal.** The veteran receives automatic updates. When a decision arrives, it is analyzed the same day, the appeal lane is chosen within the one-year window, and the cycle repeats until the case is resolved.

Single-Entry Design - Fill It Once, It Flows Everywhere

This is the lawyer's core requirement, and it is treated in this plan as a core design rule - not an add-on. In VA practice the same facts are asked for again and again: on the intake, on the claim, on every appeal form, on every statement and cover sheet. In this system, no one re-types them. A fact is entered or verified once, and every document that needs it pulls it from one place.

1. One master record per veteran - the golden record

Every veteran has a single master case record. It is the only source of truth for the facts the firm uses across the whole case. It is created at intake, verified by staff, and updated only through the master record - never by editing a single form in isolation.

Block	What it holds
Identity	Full legal name, Social Security number, date of birth, VA file number
Contact	Mailing address, phone, email, preferred contact method, dependents where relevant
Service history	Branch, service dates, units, deployments, and exposure history as documented in the record
Conditions & ratings	Conditions claimed, conditions rated, current percentages, and prior decision history
Representation	Accredited representative on file, fee agreement status, and key filing dates

Documents the veteran uploads - DD Form 214, decision letters, medical records - feed this record through extraction, but staff verify the extracted facts before the record is treated as verified. Unverified fields are flagged, not trusted.

2. A field-mapping library across every form

Behind the system sits a field-mapping library: for every VA form the firm uses, each field is mapped once to the master record, a case field, or a filing-specific answer. VA forms repeat the same identity and service blocks constantly - the library is what makes that repetition free.

Document	What auto-fills from the master record
21-526EZ - Claim	Identity, contact, service history, conditions list
20-0995 - Supplemental Claim	Identity, prior decision reference, conditions at issue
20-0996 - Higher-Level Review	Identity, decision date, issues for review
10182 - Board Appeal	Identity, decision reference, appeal lane and issues
21-22a - Representation	Identity, representative details, contact block
Statements & cover sheets	Name, file number, service summary, signature blocks

Nobody re-types a name, a date, or a service number to fill any of these. Staff work only on what is genuinely new for that filing - the issue, the argument, the new evidence.

How single-entry keeps working after day one

3. Change propagation - fix it once, fix it everywhere it matters

When a fact is corrected in the master record - a new address, a corrected service date, a name spelling fixed - the correction flows to every document that has not yet been filed. Documents already filed keep the copy they were filed with, exactly as submitted, and the system flags what changed and when, so the file always shows both the history and the current truth. Nothing is silently rewritten after filing.

4. Smart reuse beyond fields

- **Prior filings copy forward.** A new filing starts from the last verified filing for that veteran, with every change highlighted for review - not from a blank form.
- **Evidence attaches itself.** Evidence already in the file that is relevant to a new claim is surfaced and attached automatically for staff to confirm, instead of being re-gathered or re-uploaded.
- **Narratives stay consistent.** Service-history summaries and standard statement language are generated from the master record, so the story the firm tells VA is word-for-word consistent across every document in the case.

5. Pre-staging - the next step starts 90% filled

When a claim is filed, the system pre-generates the likely next-step forms from the same record - the Supplemental Claim (20-0995), the Higher-Level Review request (20-0996), and the Board appeal (10182) - held as drafts, not filings. If a decision comes back unfavourable, the appeal does not start from zero: it starts roughly 90% filled, and the attorney's time goes to strategy and the specific errors to raise.

6. Guardrails - autofill never files by itself

- **Diff and review screen.** Before any filing, staff see exactly what was populated, field by field, and where each value came from - master record, prior filing, or a source document and page.
- **Conflicts stop and ask.** If source documents disagree - two different addresses, two different service dates - the system does not guess. It flags the conflict and a human resolves it in the master record.
- **Human approval still gates everything.** Single-entry removes typing, not judgment. The approval step in Engine D applies to every auto-filled document, without exception.

> **7. Where the saving comes from.** This design is the engine behind the form-preparation saving in the next section: preparation becomes review-only, because the typing was done once, at intake. It also removes a classic and costly error class - mismatched names, dates, and file numbers across forms - the kind of inconsistency that causes VA processing delays and avoidable rework.

Automation Map: Where the Hours Go

This section walks a single case from first contact to fee, step by step, and shows at each step what staff do by hand today and what the system does instead. It is the practical companion to the engine descriptions earlier in this plan.

STATUS - WHAT IS ALREADY PROVEN

Built and verified in the proof of concept (Oct 2026): decision-letter extraction to master record, autopopulation of the five core VA forms, encrypted credential vault with live connection test. Everything else in this map is build order, sequenced by hours saved.

The math in one line (planning estimates). A case that today takes an estimated 10-14 staff hours of paperwork is expected to take an estimated 4-6 hours with the system. At the firm's current volume of about 4-5 new cases a month, that is an estimated 25-40 staff hours saved each month. The full task-by-task table is in the Time & Money section; the steps below show where those hours actually sit.

1. Intake

Today - manual	With the system
Paper or PDF intake is re-typed into the case file, then typed again into the forms that need the same facts.	One guided intake creates the case file, the master record, and the welcome packet in a single pass. The fee agreement and VA Form 21-22a are generated pre-filled and sent for e-signature (Adobe Sign). Nothing is re-typed anywhere downstream.

2. Records & incoming mail Proven in proof of concept

Today - manual	With the system
Staff read every VA letter by hand and key the dates and deadlines into a tracker.	Incoming VA letters - rating decisions, denials, and exam notices - are read automatically and update the case record. Deadline clocks start from the decision date printed on the letter itself. Records requests are tracked with scheduled follow-ups instead of memory.

The reading step in this item - decision-letter extraction into the master record - is one of the pieces already built and verified in the proof of concept, as noted in the status box above.

Analysis and filings, without the re-typing

3. Decision analysis

Today - manual	With the system
Combined-ratings math is done by hand or calculator, and decisions are read line by line hunting for errors.	Combined-ratings math under 38 CFR Section 4.25 is computed and checked against what the VA actually awarded. An error scan flags wrong effective dates, conditions the decision never addressed, and ratings that do not match. A per-condition gap report shows diagnosis, in-service event, and nexus - present versus missing.

4. Forms & filings

Proven in proof of concept

Today - manual	With the system
Every VA form is typed from scratch, and filing packets are assembled by hand.	All VA forms autopopulate from the master record. Filing packets assemble automatically - form, evidence, and cover letter, in order. A deadline engine watches every clock with escalating alerts.

What "proven" means here. In the working proof of concept, the real VA forms - 21-526EZ, 20-0995, 20-0996, 10182, and 21-22a - were filled from a record extracted from a decision letter, and the filled forms were then read back, field by field, to verify that what the record supplied is what landed on each form. The forms stay editable: the attorney reviews and corrects a completed packet rather than approving a locked file.

Autopopulation removes typing, not judgment. The human approval gate described in the Compliance section applies to every auto-filled form, without exception.

Evidence, clients, and fees

5. Evidence building

Today - manual	With the system
Medical and service records are read cold to build a chronology, and statements and letters are started from a blank page.	Records are summarized into a case timeline. A condition-by-condition evidence checklist is generated from the file. Buddy statement and nexus letter drafts are started from the record, for the attorney to edit and approve.

6. Client communication

Today - manual	With the system
Staff time is burned on "any update?" calls and on chasing unsigned paperwork.	Automatic status updates go out when a case changes stage, along with C&P exam reminders and a nudge sequence when a client has not returned a signed document. A client status page lets clients check their case instead of calling.

7. Fees & admin

Today - manual	With the system
Fee math and withholding are tracked in spreadsheets after the fact.	When a grant lands, the fee is computed from the past-due benefits and tracked against the fee agreement and the VA's withholding. A weekly one-page docket digest shows what is due, what is aging, and what needs the attorney's attention.

8. Adobe handoff note

The system ships with no vendor account embedded. The firm connects its own Adobe account through the Connect Adobe setup screen, so billing and the audit trail on every document sit under the firm's name. The Adobe free tier covers 500 document transactions a month; at the firm's volume of about 4-5 new cases a month, that tier carries the practice a long way before any paid plan is needed.

> **How to use this map.** Read it as a build order, not a promise list. The two proven pieces - decision-letter extraction and form autopopulation - are the foundation already standing. Each remaining item is sequenced by the hours it saves, and each one still ends the same way: a named human reviews and approves before anything leaves the firm.

What this saves - stated honestly as estimates

Every figure below is a **planning estimate**. Real numbers vary by case complexity and will be measured in the prototype phase before any larger commitment. Nothing here is a guarantee of savings or outcomes.

Task	Typical manual time	With the system	What changes
Intake	45-90 minutes	~10 min review	Veteran answers once; facts are extracted automatically
Decision-letter analysis	1-3 hours	~15 min review	Conditions, ratings, reasons, and combined math pre-worked
Record-file summary	3-8 hours	~30 min review	Per-condition chronology with source-page links
Form preparation	1-2 hours per filing	~15 min check	Forms filled from the verified file; human approves
Status calls & chasing documents	Ongoing, daily	Largely automated	Automatic updates and reminders replace routine calls

The roll-up (estimate)

- Roughly **40-60% of administrative hours** per case are eliminated.
- A case that today consumes an estimated **10-14 staff hours** of administration consumes an estimated **4-6 hours** - the legal work itself is unchanged.
- That is how the same team carries an estimated **2-3 times the caseload**: not by working faster at the law, but by no longer hand-carrying the paperwork.

> **The value that does not fit in the table:** one missed one-year deadline can cost a veteran thousands of dollars in back pay, because a later filing generally means a later effective date. The deadline engine makes that loss structurally hard to occur - no spreadsheet or memory stands between a case and its alarm.

On fees: this plan makes no new fee claims. VA fee rules are in the Compliance section. The financial case is capacity and risk avoided, not any change to how clients are charged.

Non-negotiables, built in from day one

A system that touches veterans' medical records, benefits, and legal rights has to be more careful than a normal office tool. These are design requirements, not aspirations.

Representation and fees

- Only attorneys and agents accredited by VA represent claimants before VA. The system supports their work; it does not represent anyone.
- Fee rules are respected in the workflow itself: no fee is charged for help with an initial claim, and fees for work after an initial decision are contingency-based, agreed in writing, and kept within VA's reasonableness standards. The system tracks the agreement on file for every case.
- Advertising and outreach connected to the system follow the same rule the firm applies everywhere: no testimonial, review, or outcome claim is ever used unless it is real, verified, and given with the client's consent.

Accuracy and ethics

- **The system never fabricates.** It does not invent evidence, symptoms, service events, or statements. It drafts and organizes only what the veteran, the record, or a witness actually provided.
- **Human approval gate.** No filing, statement, letter, or other outbound assertion leaves the firm without a named human reviewing and approving it. The approval is recorded.
- **Source-linked work.** Extracted facts and chronology entries point back to the source document and page, so verification is a click, not a new search.

Security and privacy

- Encryption in transit and at rest for all case data.
- Role-based access: each person sees only the cases and functions their job requires.
- A full audit trail of who viewed, changed, approved, exported, or filed anything, and when.
- Veteran information - Social Security numbers, medical records, financial details - is treated as highly sensitive, with the minimum collection and retention the work requires.
- A written data-retention policy and a breach-response plan are adopted before the system handles its first live case.

> **The principle in one line:** the software is a tool in accredited hands. If a step would require legal judgment, a signature, or a representation to VA or to a veteran, a human does that step - every time.

Website Integration & Hosting Architecture

The public website and the claims system are two different things, on purpose. Keeping them separate is what makes the system both affordable and safe.

The website today: a public storefront, nothing more

The current Law 4 Warriors website is a **static site hosted free on GitHub Pages**. "Static" means it is a set of finished pages - text and pictures - with **no database and no server behind it** that collects or stores information. That is perfect for marketing: fast, reliable, and free. It is also a hard limit, and a protective one:

> **The public website must never hold veteran personal information, medical records, Social Security numbers, or case files.** Nothing sensitive is stored there, emailed from a website form into a file there, or passed through it in a way the firm cannot control. GitHub Pages never stores case data - at any stage of this plan.

The claims system: a separate, secure application

The AI claims system attaches to the website as the secure back end and front door for actual casework. The website's buttons - **Free Consultation, Start Intake, Upload Documents,** and **Client Login** - link or embed into that separate secure application. Once the firm's custom domain is pointed, the secure app should live on its own subdomain, such as **intake.law4warriors.com** or **app.law4warriors.com**.

To the veteran, it feels like one branded flow: same colors, same logo, no confusing change of scenery. Behind the scenes, only the secure application handles sign-in and authentication, encrypted document storage, OCR and extraction, the case dashboard, the deadline engine, and the audit logs described in this plan.

How the data flows



When the custom domain is ready

One domain can do both jobs. Domain settings (DNS) can keep the main address - www - on GitHub Pages for free, while the app or intake subdomain points to the secure system. The firm buys and controls the domain once, the public site stays free, and only the secure side carries the hosting costs in the Operating Costs section. If the secure app ever changes providers, only the subdomain moves; the public website does not.

In plain terms: the website is the sign and the front door. The secure application is the locked office, the file vault, and the alarm system - in a different building, even though the veteran walks through one doorway.

Build it in phases. Each phase pays for itself in time.

Phase 1 - The foundation (build first)

Smart Intake, document extraction, the case dashboard, and the deadline tracker. This is the 80/20: it removes most of the intake pain and immediately protects every one-year window across the whole caseload, even before the later engines exist.

Phase 2 - The analysis

The Rating-Decision Analyzer and Evidence Builder chronologies. Cases start arriving with their opportunity report and timelines already drafted for attorney review.

Phase 3 - The full loop

Form auto-fill, filing integrations through accredited-representative channels, and the full Client Autopilot. The case file built in Phases 1 and 2 now flows directly into filings and client updates.

Each phase is usable on its own. If the firm stopped after Phase 1, it would still keep the intake and deadline gains. **Buy versus build:** general tools - a customer-relationship system or case-management platform - can host scheduling, contacts, and billing, and there is no prize for rebuilding those. The VA-specific work - decision analysis, combined-ratings checks, per-condition chronologies, deadline logic - is the differentiator, and that is the part worth owning.

Timelines and costs are deliberately not quoted in this plan. They firm up after a short scoping pass on the firm's actual case volume, current tools, and document mix (Section 10). Any number given before that pass would be invented, and this plan does not invent numbers.

Risks and limits - stated plainly

- **Extraction errors.** Software can misread a poor scan or an unusual document. Mitigation: source-linked fields, confidence flags on uncertain items, and the human verification gates in Sections 3 and 6.
- **VA changes.** Forms, systems, and submission routes change. Mitigation: the form and filing layer is built to be updated without rebuilding the whole system.
- **Compliance drift.** Accreditation and advertising rules govern this practice. Mitigation: the non-negotiables in Section 6 are enforced in the workflow, not left to memory.
- **Staff adoption.** A tool nobody trusts gets worked around. Mitigation: phased rollout, training on the review role, and early wins from Phase 1.

What the system deliberately does not do: it does not give legal advice directly to veterans, does not decide the merits of any claim, and does not replace attorney judgment. Those remain, entirely, with the firm's accredited professionals.

Estimated Monthly Operating Costs

All figures in this section are **planning estimates**, to be firmed up at scoping. Vendor prices change, and the firm's actual case volume will move the real number inside - or occasionally outside - these bands.

Tier	Estimate / month	What it covers
1. Lean / Pilot	**$150-$450**	Cloud hosting for the secure app, managed database and encrypted file storage, backups, domain and SSL (the public website itself stays free on GitHub Pages), email sending, low text-message volume, and modest AI/OCR use. At small scale, extraction and summarization runs cents to a few dollars per case file.
2. Active Practice	**$500-$1,500**	Higher AI/OCR volume across many active cases, more storage for large record files, text/email automation at scale, monitoring and uptime tools, and support tools.
3. High-Volume	**$1,500-$4,000+**	Heavy document processing, large and growing storage, redundancy so one failure does not stop the practice, and a dedicated support and maintenance arrangement.

Worked example: only 4-5 new cases a month

At a very small volume - **4 to 5 new cases per month** - total running cost is roughly **$75-$200 per month**, and with lean choices it can run **under about $100 per month**:

Item	Estimate / month	Notes
Secure app hosting	$25-$75	Small cloud instance for the private application
Managed database	$15-$50	Case data, deadlines, and audit trail
Encrypted file storage	A few dollars	Roughly 5 new case files a month; storage is cheap at this scale
Backups	Minimal	Automated backups of the database and file store
Transactional email	Free tier to ~$10	Status updates and reminders to veterans
SMS / texting	A few dollars	A handful of client updates per case
Domain	~$12-$15 per year	About $1 a month; the public website itself stays free on GitHub Pages
AI / OCR usage	~$10-$50 total	About $2-$10 per case file for intake extraction, decision-letter parsing, and record chronology

The insight at low volume: fixed platform costs - hosting and the database - dominate the bill; each extra case adds only about **$5-$15** (mostly AI/OCR and messaging), so cost barely moves between 4 cases and 10. Even at 4-5 cases a month, the estimated **25-40 staff hours saved monthly** (per-case savings, Section 5) dwarfs a $75-$200 running cost. Maintenance at this scale is occasional as-needed hours, not a retainer.

What the tiers do not cover

What is NOT in those numbers

- **One-time build cost** - scoped and quoted separately after the scoping session and prototype; deliberately not estimated here.
- **Staff time** for the human review and approval gates - that is the firm's own payroll, and it is the work the system is designed to protect, not remove.
- **Existing subscriptions** - any practice-management, CRM, or other tools the firm already pays for and keeps.
- **VA filing itself** - VA charges no fee to file a claim or appeal.

> **The comparison that puts this in perspective:** one fully loaded paralegal hour - pay plus overhead - costs more than a month of the Lean tier at its low end. The system pays for itself if it saves only a handful of staff hours per month, well below the savings estimated in the Time & Money section.

Maintenance is not optional - budget for it

Budget a small monthly retainer, or a clear hourly arrangement, for updates, security patches, and VA form changes. VA forms and rules change, vendors patch their systems, and the deadline and form library at the heart of this system needs upkeep to stay trustworthy. Skipping maintenance does not save money; it quietly converts a reliable system into a risk. The retainer is separate from the hosting tiers above unless a support agreement explicitly bundles it.

Note on the small-volume example on the previous page: at 4-5 cases a month, that maintenance is realistically occasional as-needed hours rather than a retainer - but the need itself does not disappear. As volume grows toward the Active Practice tier, a small standing arrangement becomes the safer choice.

How we will know it is working

Success is measured on operations, not promises. The dashboard that runs the cases also reports these numbers, reviewed monthly by the partners.

Measure	What "good" looks like
Intake turnaround	Time from first contact to a verified, attorney-ready file - target: same business day for complete submissions (operational target, to be confirmed in scoping)
Staff hours per case (admin)	Tracked against the pre-system baseline; expected direction is the 40-60% reduction estimated in Section 5
Deadline misses	**Zero.** Any case entering its 30-day window without a filing plan is escalated automatically
Caseload per staff member	Rising capacity without rising overtime - the 2-3x estimate is tested here, in real numbers
Client response time	Status questions answered by automatic updates; human callbacks measured separately and kept prompt
Extraction accuracy	Share of extracted fields accepted without correction at review - the quality check on Engine A and B

Recommended next step

> **1. A short scoping session** with the partners and the staff who run intake today: current case volume, current tools, document mix, and the firm's real deadline-tracking method. **2. A working intake prototype** - Engine A plus the deadline tracker - tested on real, anonymized firm documents, so the partners judge actual extraction quality and real review times, not a demonstration. Only then, with measured numbers in hand, decide on the full build and its phases.

That sequence keeps the commitment small until the evidence is in. If the prototype does not save the time this plan estimates, the firm will know quickly and cheaply. If it does - and the structure of this work strongly suggests it will - the firm will have the foundation of a practice that can serve substantially more veterans, with the same team, and with every deadline protected.

They served us. Now we serve them - with a system built to keep that promise at scale.

About this document: Prepared for the partners of Law 4 Warriors for internal planning. It describes VA forms, appeal lanes, and rating concepts in general terms for planning purposes (including VA Forms 21-526EZ, 20-0995, 20-0996, 10182, and 21-22a; the one-year appeal windows that generally protect effective dates; and combined ratings under 38 CFR Section 4.25). Individual cases turn on their own facts and deadlines. This plan is not legal advice, does not create an attorney-client relationship, and contains no client testimonials or outcome claims. All time, capacity, and savings figures are planning estimates to be validated in the prototype phase.